



*Photo: The Connie & Kevin Chou Hall was added to campus in 2018, the first academic building in the US awarded both LEED Platinum and WELL certifications. The interior design encourages students to engage and collaborate.*

# FORTUNA ADMISSIONS INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO UC BERKELEY HAAS



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR BERKELEY HAAS

### ABOUT THE SCHOOL

As the second-oldest business school in the US, the Haas School of Business at the University of California, Berkeley has been questioning the status quo since its founding in 1898. The Berkeley Haas mission is to help extraordinary people achieve great things. At Haas, its distinctive culture is expressed through the four Defining Leadership Principles: Question the Status Quo, Confidence Without Attitude, Students Always, and Beyond Yourself. The Berkeley Haas culture fosters new thinking and new tools to change careers—and markets.

Across every dimension, Haas students, faculty, and staff are characterized by the high quality of their work, their exceptional talents and creativity, their diversity of experience, and their commitment to inclusiveness. Applicants select Berkeley Haas in order to join a diverse global community of people who use the tools of business to make a positive impact. Students work with and alongside others who embrace our Defining Leadership Principles—and see how their role is to contribute to a larger purpose.

Anchored in a rigorous general management curriculum, Haas links its courses and programs across disciplines at Berkeley and puts a premium on flexibility, allowing students to customize a program of study to their interests and design their own electives.

### STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Entrepreneurship, General Management, Healthcare, Innovation, International Management, Nonprofit/Social Responsibility, Organizational Behavior, Research Institutes & Centers, Tech.

### INCOMING CLASS OF 2020

Number of Applicants: 3,821  
Admissions Selectivity: 12%

MBA Class Size: 291  
Yield: 63.47%

Total Tuition: \$123,012

### POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Technology/Telecom 31.7%; Consulting 24%; Financial Services 13.7%; CPG Retail 8.2%;  
Top Recruiters: Adobe, Amazon, Bain & Company, BD, BCG, Bridgewater, Deloitte, Google  
Avg. Base Salary: \$125,572      Employment in 3 months: 93%

### MBA RANKINGS

|                 | 2012 | 2013 | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | 2018 | 2019 |
|-----------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| BusinessWeek    | 13   | -    | 19   | 9    | 10   | 11   | 6    | -    |
| Financial Times | 7    | 7    | 8    | 7    | 5    | 8    | 7    | 10   |
| Forbes          | -    | 14   | -    | 8    | -    | 9    | -    | -    |
| The Economist   | 6    | 3    | 5    | 5    | 7    | 7    | 10   | -    |
| US News         | 7    | 7    | 7    | 7    | 7    | 7    | 7    | 6    |

### ADMISSIONS

Avg. Yrs Work Experience: 5.4  
Int'l Students: 42%

Avg. GMAT: 726  
Female Students: 43%

Avg. GPA: 3.66

### Deadlines for 2019-2020:

R1 – Sept. 26, '19

R2 – Jan. 9, '20

R3 – April 2, '20

NEW Round 3 extended deadline: May 4, 2020 \*Covid-19 update as of 3/30/20

Sources: Berkeley Haas, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, Forbes, The Economist, US News, MBA50



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR UC BERKELEY HAAS

### ESSAYS ANALYSIS 2019-2020

By Dr. Sharon Joyce

*Sharon is a seasoned professional in higher education who served as the Associate Director of Admissions for the full-time program MBA program at Berkeley Haas, while also collaborating on the overall strategic plan for admissions as a member of the Senior Management team.*

To kick off the 2019-2020 application season, Berkeley Haas refreshed all three of its essay questions (two required, one optional). Gone is the tricky, Hemingwayesque six-word story prompt and the invitation to describe your immediate post-MBA career goal. The spirit of Haas's optional question remains intact, yet it is distilled from nearly 200 words of explicit context-setting (for a 300-word response) into two elegant sentences.

As former Associate Director of Admissions at Berkeley Haas, I think the new suite of questions is excellent. Here's what Haas is looking for in each of its new questions and my advice on how to tackle them:

**Required essay #1:** *What makes you feel alive when you are doing it, and why?*

I love the wording of this question – any opportunity to learn about what ignites the spark in a candidate is really exciting to read. This question also underscores that Haas is looking for people who will actively contribute to the community and beyond, not just in the classroom. Your intellectual acumen and accomplishments a given, what are you passionate about and why does it ignite that aliveness in you? This essay prompt allows the admissions team to understand 'what makes you tick' up and beyond what they'll glean from your academic record and work history.

Given that you only have 300 words, the maxim to 'show not tell' is critical here. You want to bring the reader on the experience with you so they can smell, taste, feel and connect to whatever it is you're describing – what it felt like to summit that mountaintop and peer into the volcano's smoky belly, or the felt experience in a devotional act of creation that erased any sense of time. And unless it's deeply sincere and will ring true, a community service moment or tutoring exchange isn't necessarily the place to shine the spotlight. Dig deep and dare to have a little fun here; your voice can convey your personality.

**Required essay #2:** *At Berkeley Haas, we are redefining leadership. We value different opinions and perspectives, recognizing that we always have more to learn about others' lived experiences and histories. We encourage speaking up and listening, and courageously use our power to address barriers and drive change for positive impact. Tell us how a Berkeley Haas MBA would enhance your leadership profile, incorporating specific examples.*

The context Haas offers in the set-up for this question is vitally important. The school has long put a premium on challenging the status quo (first among its four defining leadership principles) – and the status quo continues to perpetuate inequity and power dynamics that privilege certain groups and marginalize others. Berkeley Haas is at the forefront of addressing inclusivity in b-school and beyond, seeking to create and cultivate a community that reflects genuine diversity in every sense of the word. As such, Haas is looking for candidates who demonstrate self- and situational awareness, which is an invitation to recognize your privilege and convey a deep understanding of what that means to you as a leader. (*cont. on next page*)



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR UC BERKELEY HAAS

In phrasing this question, Haas is looking to see that you've really done your research, up and beyond the cursory website review. You only have 300 words, and you'll want to get specific, not speak in generalities on how its guiding principles resonate. Whether it's getting involved with the annual Women In Leadership conference or working with Severin Borenstein at the Energy Institute, you'll want to speak with precision and authenticity about ways you're hoping to increase your leadership profile. In doing so, how can you convey a nuanced understanding of what it means to be an ethical leader who values the opinions and perspectives of others?

**New Optional Essay:** *In addition to the two required essays, candidates who wish to tell us about how they have responded to hardships or unusual life circumstances are encouraged to complete the optional essay. This information will provide context to your opportunities & achievements and contribute to our holistic review of your application.*

While this question is rephrased from last year's optional essay, the spirit behind the asking is the same. In asking this question, Haas seeks to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates' lives, opportunities, decisions, and character. This optional essay is a way for the admissions committee to recognize the challenges certain applicants face to get to where they are – even when students themselves don't see them as distinctive or noteworthy.

Socioeconomic barriers, for example, can contribute to things that might be missing from an application but, in context, convey bigger picture understanding. As I wrote previously when Haas's optional essay made its debut, it's a recognition from Haas of the huge range of students applying to business school, and a desire to support the admissions committee's decision-making by supplying a full and rich understanding of who each applicant truly is.

If you're feeling equal parts inspired and intimidated, take to heart these unscripted remarks from Berkeley Haas's Pete Johnson, Assistant Dean for the Full-time MBA Program and Admissions. Speaking on the Admissions Director Panel at the CentreCourt MBA Festival in New York, Johnson offered the following advice:

"Be courageous. I think a lot of applicants say 'well, you know, I'm an engineer but what I really want to do is work in digital music,' and they write it out and they show it to their partner or whoever who says, 'no don't write that, they'll think you're crazy!' When people do that, it goes flat. When somebody really tells us what they're enthusiastic about it literally leaps off the screen when we read those things."



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR BERKELEY HAAS

By Dr. Sharon Joyce

Here are Sharon's five top tips on crafting a standout application to Berkeley Haas:

### Tip #1 – The Berkeley Haas Defining Leadership Principles are a REAL thing

The four principles – Question the Status Quo, Confidence Without Attitude, Students Always, and Beyond Yourself – are truly reflective of the school's culture and not just marketing fodder. Prepare to demonstrate how and why these principles speak to you. In the Haas interview, for example, you may be asked which one resonates most. There isn't a right or wrong reply to this and it's not a trick, but your ability to be authentic and honest in response depends on whether you've taken the time to get introspective about both the principles and your fit with the program.

### Tip #2 – Berkeley Haas takes pride in being part of a larger a public institution

It's important to demonstrate some awareness that Berkeley Haas is part of the University of California system, with Berkeley being its flagship campus. The University of California was founded in 1868, born out of a vision in the State Constitution of a university that would "contribute even more than California's gold to the glory and happiness of advancing generations." UC Berkeley students – Haas students included – are reputed to be "scrappier" than peers at private institutions as well as lauded by recruiters for being less "entitled," which ties directly to the Confidence Without Attitude principle.

### Tip #3 – Diversity of cultures and perspectives are the hallmarks of Berkeley Haas

The school is committed to recruiting the most diverse students, faculty, and staff to enhance the mission, community, and academic excellence. In the essay prompts you're asked to consider, the Admissions Committee is seeking to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates' lives, opportunities, decisions, and character. Whether you're someone with privilege or not, you can express your values, political engagement, awareness of social justice, and/or access to education in terms of social mobility – all of which are very important to Haas. This school seeks students who demonstrate self-awareness and community engagement, which is an invitation to recognize your privilege and convey a deep understanding of what that means to you. Overall, Haas genuinely fosters a climate of inclusion, empathy, and compassion. Even if you don't identify as a member of a marginalized group, it can be valuable to show how you are an ally and welcoming of different ways of thinking, which ties to Questioning the Status Quo and Beyond Yourself.

### Tip #4 – It's okay to be a little bit "Bezerkeley"

The term "Beserkeley" has a history in popular culture and media lingo. In 2004, the current top definition for the word "Bezerkeley," a popular spelling variant of the word, was created on Urban Dictionary. The word as read on the site is defined simply as "Berkeley, California," as if the name of the city alone were enough to express the out-there atmosphere associated with the locale. How does this apply to Berkeley Haas? The Admissions Committee does place some value on being a bit quirky – if this is authentically who you are. (But don't fake it if you're not!) The acceptance of those who might have taken a path less traveled, or who have an unusual talent or hobby, is what makes the Haas student body so unique. The essay prompts tend to be less conventional by design; the admissions committee wants to find out what makes you tick, up and beyond your work and academic acumen. You should approach the prompts with enthusiasm, gusto and as a signal of your fit for the program.



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR BERKELEY HAAS

### Tip #5 – Community engagement is requisite

The student-driven and deeply participatory atmosphere at Haas is another vital differentiator to connect to your narrative. Haas's culture of engagement extends beyond studies into institutional operations, with feedback loops between student government and every administrative function/office within the program. Student viewpoints are taken very seriously and are actively solicited. Admissions interviews are predominately conducted by student interviewers, for example, and their reviews of candidates are weighed equally to those conducted by alumni and professional staff.

As such, if you're among the fortunate to be invited to interview, know that current students, who serve as interviewers, can be tough evaluators. You will need to cite two-to-three clubs you plan to join at Haas, as well as link at least one club with experience or position you've served in the past to demonstrate your commitment, sincerity and track record of community engagement. So earlier on in the application process, be sure to reach out to student leadership to have a few examples of how you'll be an active participant.

---

### More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

